



The Library of Whispering Trees

By Einav Momi Ben Shushan and Chen Tzafir



Talia was a girl with curls that had a mind of their own. They hopped, skipped, and jumped whenever she explored. Today, her adventurous curls led her further into the garden than ever before, right to the edge of the Ancient Woods.



Beneath the giant ferns, Talia spotted something shimmering. It wasn't a flower or a bug, but a trail of pebbles that glowed with a soft, pulsing violet light, winding deep into the shadows.



She followed the path until the woods opened into a magnificent clearing. The trees here were unlike any Talia had ever seen. Their trunks were wide, and instead of rough bark, they held massive, open pages that spilled warm, golden light onto the forest floor.



"Careful not to smudge the ink!" a tiny, chime-like voice warned. Out from behind a glowing leaf fluttered a small fairy with wings that looked like translucent maps. She zipped right up to Talia's nose.

"I am Ziv," the fairy chirped, spinning in a dizzying circle. She flew to the nearest tree and pressed her tiny hand against a page. The golden light rippled like water, and the letters began to dance and swirl.



As Talia watched, the dancing letters formed the shape of a silver dragon. It leaped from the tree, swooping through the air and leaving a trail of glittery smoke that smelled like old books and pine needles.



Talia wandered deeper into the library. She found a tree that was different from the others. Its pages were bright and blank, humming with a quiet, expectant energy. She reached out, her fingers trembling with wonder.



"That tree is waiting for a new story," Ziv explained, landing softly on a nearby mushroom. "It doesn't tell the past; it listens to the now. It needs someone with a brave heart and very messy hair."



When the stars began to peek through the canopy, Talia knew it was time to go. She arrived home with twigs in her curls and a glow in her heart. On her nightstand sat a single golden leaf, a library card for a forest that never stops telling stories.